Week 4 Teacher Guide: Two Righteousnesses, and How God Is Known

The Obedience of Faith, Week 4 of 12. Opens Unit II (Discernment).

Companion to Week04-TwoRighteousnesses.pptx.

Scripture from the NET Bible.

Aim: Ground the whole course in grace before pressing further: the difference between self-built righteousness and God's gift-righteousness, and the New Covenant promise of truly knowing God.

What this week must accomplish (and nothing more): the class leaves holding one sentence and believing it: *obedience is the shape of faith, not its price.* This is the single most important week in the twelve for keeping the course from being heard as works-salvation. Everything before it (three weeks of "sincerity isn't enough") has deliberately created a little pressure; this week releases it into grace. Everything after it (tests, sacrifice, order, commission) describes obedience and will be misheard as earning unless this week lands.

Where this sits in the arc: Weeks 1–3 diagnosed. This is the turn. The emotional job of the hour is *relief*: the class has been shown that sincerity and results both fail as standards, and some thoughtful members are quietly wondering whether they themselves are sincere-but-lost. The answer is not "try harder to be sincere in the right way." The answer is a different righteousness altogether, received rather than achieved. Lead with that relief; don't make them wait for it.

Presentation

Segment 1: Two Kinds of Righteousness (0:00–15:00 · Slide 2)

Open by naming the turn out loud: "For three weeks we've seen sincerity isn't enough and results aren't enough. If the ground feels shaky, good; today we put it back, and its name is grace."

The two columns build on clicks.

Left: the righteousness of man (first click). Read it as the *respectable* version. This is not the drunk in the ditch; this is the diligent, church-attending, morally serious person: the scribes and Pharisees, who were the best people of their day by every visible measure. Built on self-trust, measured by effort and comparison and behavior. Strong on the outside, and (this is the whole point) unable to stand before God. Connect it back: this is exactly Weeks 1–3's failure named at its *root*. The new cart,

the edited command, the clear-but-wrong conscience; all of it grows from one seedbed: a self-built approach to God. Its motto: *prove yourself*.

Right: the righteousness of God (second click). Note the reversed starting point. Man's righteousness begins with what I do; God's begins with what Christ has done. It is given by grace, received through faith, grounded in Christ. **Guard immediately against the antinomian (oposition to moral or religious laws) mishearing:** the right column still "produces a new life that changes how we live"; grace is not indifference to holiness. The difference is *direction of flow*: the changed life flows *from* the gift, not *toward* it as payment. Motto: *trust Christ.*

Matthew 5:20 (third click). "Unless your righteousness *goes beyond* that of the experts in the law…" The natural misreading is "be a better Pharisee: keep more rules, keep them harder." Jesus means the opposite: he points *past* that entire category to a righteousness of a different kind and source. You cannot out-Pharisee the Pharisees into the kingdom; you need someone else's righteousness.

Romans 10:3–4 (fourth click). Read verse 2 first, aloud, because it is the whole tragedy: Israel had *zeal* for God (real, costly, sincere zeal). Their failure was not too little effort. It was zeal aimed at "establishing their own righteousness," refusing to "submit to God's." And "Christ is the end of the law" (*telos*, the goal the law was always pointing toward), "with the result that there is righteousness for everyone who believes." Land the danger sentence: a person can be serious, religious, and sincere, and still miss God: by building his own.

Transition: "If righteousness is a gift, then knowing God can't be an achievement either. So how *is* He known?"

Segment 2: How God Is Actually Known (15:00–30:00 · Slide 3)

Three stages, five minutes each, one click apiece. The through-line: knowing God is His work *in* you, not your climb *toward* Him.

PROMISED: Jeremiah 31:31–34 (first click). The New Covenant's defining promise. Note precisely what was wrong with the old arrangement: not the law itself (the law was holy, Rom 7:12) but its *location*: external, on tablets, outside the heart. God promises to move it inside: "I will put my law within them… write it on their hearts." The result clause is the payoff: "they will all know me, from the least of them to the greatest." Teach the Hebrew sense of "know" (*yada*): it is relational and covenantal, the word used for the deepest personal knowledge, not the word for information. This is the promise the entire New Testament announces has now arrived.

BORN: John 3:3–6 (second click). Nicodemus is the perfect case study for this exact week: a Pharisee, a ruler, a righteousness-of-man expert at the top of his field, and Jesus tells *him* he must be "born from above." You cannot achieve a birth. A birth happens *to* you; the one being born contributes nothing. "What is born of the Spirit is spirit": the new creation begins in the human spirit, God's doing from first to last (2 Cor 5:17). The expert must become an infant. That is grace's offense and grace's mercy.

WITNESSED: Romans 8:2, 9–16 (third click). The *felt* reality of the promise kept. The Spirit sets free from the law of sin and death (8:2), dwells inside the believer (8:9), gives life (8:11), and, at the pastoral summit, "bears witness to our spirit that we are God's children" (8:16). Connect this deliberately to Week 1's unresolved unease ("devotion is invisible, even to its owner"): here is God's answer. Assurance does not rest on reading your own performance scorecard; it rests on the Spirit's inner witness of belonging, grounded in God's work. Land the summary line: knowing God is His work in you.

Transition: "Now, why put this week *here*, right in the middle of a course about obedience?"

Segment 3: Why This Week Sits Here (30:00–40:00 · Slide 4)

This is the theological keystone of all twelve weeks. Do not rush it, do not trim it.

Name the risk honestly (first click). Everything ahead (covenant tests, living sacrifice, church order, commission) describes *obedience*. A course this saturated in obedience *can* be misheard as "earn your standing with God." We are inoculating against that misreading now, on purpose, before the obedience-heavy units begin.

The sentence to memorize (second click): *obedience is the shape of faith, not its price.* Have the class say it aloud. This is Week 4's version of "mercy first, altar second," and it recurs by design at Weeks 7, 9, and 12; tell them so.

The exodus order (third click): the master pattern that settles the question from the structure of redemption itself. God redeemed Israel from Egypt by blood and grace (the Passover lamb, the Red Sea), and *then*, afterward, brought them into the wilderness to be tested (Deut 8:2, which sits in chapter 8, long after the rescue in Exodus 12–14). The sequence is unbreakable and it is everywhere: rescue first, tests second. The tests never *bought* the freedom; they proved and shaped a people already free. Sinai's law followed the exodus; it did not purchase it. When you reach Unit III's covenant tests, this is the frame that keeps them from becoming a ladder.

Ephesians 2:8–10 (fourth click) seals it in one breath: "by grace you are saved through faith… not from works"; immediately he adds, "created in Christ Jesus for good works." Saved *for* good works, never *by* them. Same grace-then-life order as the exodus. Mercy first, altar second.

Segment 4: One Root, Two Poisons (40:00–42:00 · Slide 5)

This short slide teaches the insight discussion Q1 is fishing for; you can teach it here and let discussion deepen it, or hold it and let the class discover it. By the clock, teaching it here is usually the safer choice; a discovered insight that never gets discovered leaves the question flat.

Pride and despair are two readings of one scoreboard (clicks 1–2). Pride when the scorecard reads well ("I'm doing better than they are"); despair when it reads badly ("I'll never be enough"). The arrow between them shows they are the *same system* in two states, and pride is fragile, one bad week from flipping to despair.

The shared root (third click): both keep score; both make *my performance* the measure of my standing before God. This is why self-righteousness fails you no matter how you're doing: win and it makes you a Pharisee; lose and it makes you a wreck.

The cure (fourth click) is not "score higher" or "stop caring." It is a different righteousness entirely: "no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (Rom 8:1). The proud man and the despairing man need the identical sentence: not a better score, but Christ's. Close with the sustaining note: depend on Him daily, all the way through; the grace that saves is the grace that sustains. That line sets up discussion Q2.

Segments 5–6: Discussion and Close (45:00–57:00 · Slides 6–7)

Q1: "How do pride and despair grow from the same root? Which is your default?" If slide 5 taught the mechanism, use discussion to make it personal; most people lean strongly one way. Naming your own default is the win. Handle gently: someone admitting habitual despair is on tender ground, and the pastoral answer is Romans 8:1, not "cheer up."

Q2: "What does daily dependence on given-righteousness actually look like on an ordinary Tuesday?" This is the week's practical payoff; keep it concrete. Good directions: confessing sin without wallowing in it; *receiving* forgiveness rather than trying to re-earn it; serving from acceptance rather than for it; resting on a finished work when you've failed by mid-afternoon. Seed if the room is quiet: "What changes about how you pray after a genuinely bad day?" The gap between "I'll make it up to God" and "I'll bring it to God" is the whole lesson.

The close (slide 7, ~2 min). The bridge into Unit II's method: a gift this valuable *will* be counterfeited, so next week we learn to tell real from fake: the Berean method. Next week's reading is Acts 17:10–12 (watch *both halves* of what the Bereans did) and 1 Corinthians 2:6–16 (how spiritual truth is known, and why it can't be reasoned to from outside). Preview Week 5. Carry sentence: say it together; it is the course's spine. Then send them out on Romans 8:1: *no condemnation*, not a to-do list. A grace week must end on grace. Dismiss on time.

Answers to Questions You May Get

"If righteousness is a gift and there's no condemnation, why obey at all?" This is the antinomian question, and Paul asked it himself: "Are we to remain in sin so that grace may increase? Absolutely not!" (Rom 6:1–2). The answer is the week's thesis: obedience is faith's *shape*, not its price. A rescued

person doesn't obey to get rescued; he obeys because he *is* rescued and now belongs to a new master (Rom 6, which is Week 8's territory). Grace doesn't remove the reason to obey; it changes it from fear to love (1 John 4:18–19). Flag that the course's whole back half is obedience *flowing from* this week's grace.

"How is 'they will all know me' true, when plenty of church members don't seem to know God?" Jeremiah's promise defines the *covenant community* by direct knowledge of God, which is exactly why the New Testament is so concerned with counterfeits and self-examination (next week, and Week 8's "by this we know"). The promise is not "everyone in a pew automatically knows God"; it's that under the New Covenant, knowing God personally is the *normal, promised* state of a true member, not a privilege reserved for priests and prophets as under the old arrangement. Someone who genuinely doesn't know God is being invited *into* the promise, not excluded by a technicality.

"Isn't 'Christ is the end of the law' saying the law is abolished, so morality doesn't matter?" *Telos* means goal or fulfillment, not merely termination: Christ is what the law was always pointing toward and driving people to. The moral law's demands are not lowered in Christ; they're met in him and then written on the heart (Jer 31) so they're kept from the inside rather than imposed from outside. Jesus intensified the law's moral reach (Matt 5:21–48) even as he freed us from it as a system of earning. End of law-as-ladder; not end of holiness.

"You said the Pharisees were sincere and lost. How do I know I'm not in the same position right now?" Take this seriously: it may be the realest question anyone asks all term, and it's a sign the diagnosis landed. The answer is the whole point of the week: stop trying to verify your own righteousness (that's the scoreboard again) and rest on Christ's. Then look for the Spirit's witness (Rom 8:16) and its fruit (not to earn assurance, but as its confirmation). Point forward gently: Week 8's "by this we know" gives concrete tests, and they are tests of a faith already resting on grace, not entrance exams. For now: the Pharisee's problem wasn't that he examined himself too little; it's that he trusted what he found. The cure is trusting Christ instead.

"Is this 'faith alone,' or are you teaching the Reformation view?" Keep it text-anchored rather than tribal. The course teaches what Romans, Ephesians 2, and Philippians 3 say: righteousness is God's gift received by faith, producing (never purchased by) a life of obedience. Believers from many traditions affirm that grace precedes and enables obedience; where traditions differ on the finer mechanics, that's legitimate study-ground, and the course's method is to reason from the text rather than wave a banner. The sentence everyone in the room can stand on: mercy first, altar second.

Prep Checklist

- [ ] Read Romans 10:1–13 whole: verse 2 ("they have a zeal for God") is essential to the tragedy
- [ ] Read John 3:1–15: Nicodemus as the righteousness-of-man expert who must be reborn
- [ ] Read Romans 8:1–17 slowly; be ready to distinguish assurance-by-witness from assurance-by-scorecard
- [ ] Reread Exodus 12–20 in outline so the "redeemed *then* tested" sequence is at your fingertips

- [ ] Decide whether you'll teach the pride/despair root on slide 5 or hold it for discovery in discussion
- [ ] Rehearse the three New-Covenant stages against the clock (Jeremiah 15:00, John 20:00, Romans 25:00)
- [ ] Print/post next week's reading, flagging "both halves" for Acts 17

If You Run Long

Cut in this order: compress the two-column read on slide 2 (let the slide speak; summarize each side in a sentence); trim the Ephesians 2 quotation on slide 4 to verses 8–9 (keep "not from works"); hold the pride/despair slide's cure-click detail. **Never cut:** the memorized sentence on slide 4 ("shape of faith, not its price"), the exodus-order click (it is the keystone argument), or Romans 8:1 as the closing send-off. If discussion must shrink, keep Q2: the practical "ordinary Tuesday" question is what makes grace livable, and a grace week that stays abstract hasn't landed.